

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

(PLEASE PRINT OR TYPE. ATTACH PHOTOGRAPHS, DRAWINGS AND ADDITIONAL PAGES AS NECESSARY)

SPECIES: Arctic Tern Sterna paradisaea
 (Common Name) (Scientific Name)

DATE(S) OF OBSERVATION: October 9, 2000

NUMBER OF BIRDS SEEN: 2 juv. SEX: ? PLUMAGE: juv.

EXACT LOCATION: Chatfield State Park, Marina sandspit and reservoir

COUNTY: Douglas NEAREST TOWN: Littleton ELEVATION: 5300'

LENGTH OF OBSERVATION: 1 hour TIME(S) OF OBSERVATION: 1115-1215

OTHER OBSERVERS WHO SAW THE BIRD(S) WITH YOU:

Vic Zerbi CFO member

OTHER OBSERVERS WHO INDEPENDENTLY SAW THE BIRD(S):

many

LIGHT CONDITIONS (QUALITY; DIRECTION RELATIVE TO BIRD(S); POSITION): Full sun. Viewed terns from east, looking west, all sides exposed as it walked about and several times flew off in various directions nearby over the reservoir.

OPTICAL EQUIPMENT USED:

Swarovski 8 x 56 bino and Kowa TSN 4, 20-60 zoom scope

DISTANCE FROM BIRD (ESTIMATED UNLESS OTHERWISE NOTED): 20-30 yds when resting;

farther away in flight. WAS BIRD PHOTOGRAPHED? no IF SO, HAVE YOU SUBMITTED PHOTOS?

WHO TOOK THE PHOTOGRAPHS?

DESCRIBE THE GENERAL AND SPECIFIC HABITAT IN WHICH THE BIRD(S) OCCURRED:

Large man-made reservoir southwest of Metro Denver, used for flood control and recreation. Terns at large sandspit north of marina; cottonwoods and willows lined beach leading to spit.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD'S BEHAVIOR (FLYING; FEEDING; HABITS; BEHAVIORS USED IN IDENTIFYING THE SPECIES OR IN SUPPORTING THE IDENTIFICATION): Quietly resting on sand with Ring-billed Gulls, Common Tern (1), Forster's Terns (4); walking about. In flight, diving, feeding on tiny fish visible in terns' bills.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD IN DETAIL. THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PART OF THIS REPORT. INCLUDE THE OVERALL SIZE AND SHAPE AND HOW YOU PLACED THE BIRD IN THE GENERAL GROUP THAT YOU DID. GIVE COMPLETE DETAILS OF PLUMAGE, INCLUDING HEAD, THROAT, UNDERSIDES, NAPE, BACK, WINGS AND TAIL. GIVE PARTICULAR EMPHASIS TO MARKS YOU USED TO IDENTIFY THE BIRD(S). DESCRIBE OTHER DETAILS, SUCH AS COLOR AND SHAPE OF BILL, LEGS, EYE, ETC. THAT WERE IMPORTANT IN MAKING THE IDENTIFICATION. (FILL OUT THIS PORTION EVEN IF PHOTOGRAPHS ARE SUBMITTED; YOU MAY ATTACH ADDITIONAL SHEETS, DRAWINGS, FIELD SKETCHES OR COPY OF FIELD NOTES):

see attached

DESCRIBE BIRD'S CALL OR SONG:

none

DISCUSS SIMILAR SPECIES AND HOW YOU ELIMINATED THEM: All 3 tern species were visible together in one scope view! , a missed photo op. In comparison, Common Tern is stockier in size, has longer legs and bill. Legs pastel orange. (1st winter seen)
In flight, the COTE showed dusky bar through secondaries and darker gray coverts and primaries. When resting on spit, carpal bar was prominently blackish, contrasting with only faint dusky carpal bar of Arctic Tern. Adult basic Forster's Tern was bulkier, longer-legged and noticeably longer billed; lacked sooty crown and nape.

WHAT IS YOUR PRIOR EXPERIENCE WITH THIS AND SIMILARLY APPEARING SPECIES?

Have seen many Forster's Terns throughout U.S.; good numbers of Common Terns in western U.S. and several Arctic Terns in Alaska in 1995.

LIST BOOKS, GUIDES, RECORDINGS OR OTHER SOURCES CONSULTED AND HOW THIS INFLUENCED YOUR IDENTIFICATION (DURING AND AFTER OBSERVATION):

Referred to National Geo after observation to study juvenal features. Compared that text with Seabirds comments relating to similarities/differences between 1st year ARTE and COTE. A mutual exchange of observations with Vic Z. was helpful also.

THIS REPORT WAS MADE FROM NOTES MADE DURING x OR AFTER OBSERVATION, OR LATER FROM MEMORY .

DATE OF WRITTEN REPORT: October 9, 2000

REPORTING OBSERVER: Karleen Schofield

SIGNATURE: Karleen Schofield

OBSERVER ADDRESS: 33 Yates St., Denver, CO. 80219
303 936-8661

SEND REPORT TO:

COLORADO BIRD RECORDS COMMITTEE
c/o BILL LISOWSKY
2919 SILVERPLUME DR.
FT. COLLINS, CO 80526

Description: Small sized tern. Noticeably more petite in size than nearby 1st winter Common Tern and adult winter Forster's Tern.

Uppers: Head small and round, forehead white; black-streaked crown becoming more solid black through nape, through auriculars and around dark eye. Face white. White collar at hindneck separated nape from gray mantle. Black bill - slender, short, pointed with hint of orange at base of lower mandible.

Mantle, lower back, scapulars and upper wing coverts all light gray, edged with dark gray (scalloped effect). These feathers worn/jagged, as though clipped with pinkish shears. Rump was white.

Tail - white, forked, dark edging on outer rectrices visible when perched.

Wings at rest: pointed, only slightly grayer than rest of uppers; longer than tail with white edges to tips of primaries. Dusky carpal bar. Underside of P10 and possibly P9 visibly darker the full length of primary.

Wings in flight: Primaries pale with narrow dark trailing edge. Secondaries and inner primaries were paler, more translucent than outer primaries. Wing linings white. Fast, fluid, deep wingbeats. Wings folded during plunge-dive feeding.

Underparts: plain white throughout. Legs - thin, very short, dark pink to orange/red depending on light direction. Legs so short, belly appeared to nearly brush surface of sand when walking about.